



MERU Rides on OPEN SOURCE!

For India's popular taxi service, Meru Cabs, open source technology has proved to be a winner. This technology is used not only for the back-end services but also for customer-facing interfaces. **Nilesh Sangoi, CTO, Meru Cabs**, speaks with **Diksha P. Gupta** from **Open Source For You** about how open source technology has become one of the most important parts of Meru Cabs. Read on...

One of the most popular taxi services in India, Meru Cabs, is unabashedly driven by open source technology. And this is not just for the back-end services—with tools like Web and mobile apps, open source technology runs on the front-end too. As Nilesh Sangoi, CTO, Meru Cabs, explains, “This entire business is built on the foundation of technology, which is not just an enabler in our case. Ours is a technology business, altogether. From the very first day in 2007, when our first car went on the road, we had ensured that each car is fitted with a GPS/GPRS and we have an automated dispatch system at the back-end. We knew that this would be a high-scale business that could not be run by calling the driver and telling him where to go. We ensured that the system knows exactly where each cab is, and whether it is free, on hire or if the driver is no longer on duty. We wanted the system to be aware of these details so that, based on the customer's location, it could identify the ideal cab for that particular customer and automatically dispatch it.”

Most of the company's business is driven by its applications. Sangoi shares, “A large portion of our bookings is moving to apps. Almost 75 per cent of our bookings are now digital, and this number is going up really fast. A lot of migration is happening from the other channels to the app, which means the use of technology is increasing even further. Any which way, technology was never only at the back-end of our system. Even the call centre was always managed through technology. Now, what has changed is that the technology is much more visible to the end consumer. So, technology is at the forefront when it comes to Meru Cabs.”

Not possible without open source...

Meru's tryst with open source began about six years back, with the creation of its website, which was entirely on open source. The company started with the LAMP stack. Sangoi says, “Linux had arrived by then and was pretty popular. Most of the Web servers by then were on Apache.”

